

Ezra 3:7 we are told how cedar-wood for the building of the temple was brought to the Jews from Lebanon "*according to the grant which they had from Cyrus, king of Persia;*" but the preceding narrative, in our canonical recension, contains no record of any such grant. But in this fragment of the Chronicler's history which survives in First Esdras, in 4:48, we have the edict to which reference was made: "He (Cyrus) wrote letters also unto . . . those that were in Lebanon, that they should bring cedar-wood from Lebanon to Jerusalem." Again in Ezra 3:1 (= I Esdr. 5:46 [47]) there is a statement of time which presupposes a definite date in the preceding narrative. Just after the long list of returning exiles, and the subjoined statement that the people arrived in Jerusalem and settled there and in the neighboring cities, the narrative continues: "And when the seventh month was come," etc. In our canonical Ezra there is no preceding date, to which this can be referred. The date in 1:1, "The first year of Cyrus, King of Persia," is not to be thought of, both because it is too indefinite and because the time would be far too short. And the Chronicler is particular about such matters as these; see, for example, Ezra 7:8, 9, and 8:31. But in the First Esdras recension, just before this list of returning exiles, we find the missing date, in 5:6 (the verse which has already been discussed; see above).

First Esdras, then contains a portion of the Chronicler's history which has been lost from our canonical book of Ezra. The original narrative passed directly on from 2:14 (= Ezra 1:11) to 4:47, which began thus: "[And Cyrus the king] wrote letters for him (i. e., for Sheshbazzar) unto all the administrators and governors," etc. Then, after the section 4:47-56, there followed immediately 4:62-5:6, and then 5:7 ff. (= Ezra 2:1 ff.). There is no reason to doubt that the history, as thus restored, is complete and in the very same form which its author gave it.

The interpolator, for his part, wrote 4:43-46, and the first clause of vs. 47 (altering the original slightly here), and vss. 57-61. He also changed "Cyrus" to "Darius" in 5:2 and 5:6, and inserted a gloss in the latter verse.¹² Whether the gloss in 4:13 is from him, or from a previous hand, may be questioned. It was he, finally, who transposed the Artaxerxes correspondence, Ezra 4:6-24, to the place where it now stands in First Esdras.

¹² The "Joachim" of this verse came from a misread יְחִיָּהּ, as I have shown elsewhere.